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Built to Be Photographed: Conspicuous Consumption and the Co-Creation of Instagrammable Tourist Attractions in the Global South

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Tourism is more than a service co-created at the moment of delivery: it is an **experience** that is planned, enacted, and remembered.



A new category of tourist attraction has emerged, one whose value resides not in historical significance or cultural depth, but in its capacity to function as a photogenic backdrop for self-presentation. Purpose-built, visually oriented attractions have proliferated across the Global South, engineered to be photographed and shared rather than experienced in the conventional sense.

South America

1. Kame Park in Tauramena (COL)
2. Noah's Ark in Tauramena (COL)
3. Mad House in Guatavita (COL)
4. Piggy Bank in Ráquira (COL)
5. Lionel Messi in Aldo Beroisa (ARG)











Europe, USA, China





① Haus steht Kopf (“House upside down”) in Terfens (Austria)

② Museum of Illusions in Stuttgart (Germany)

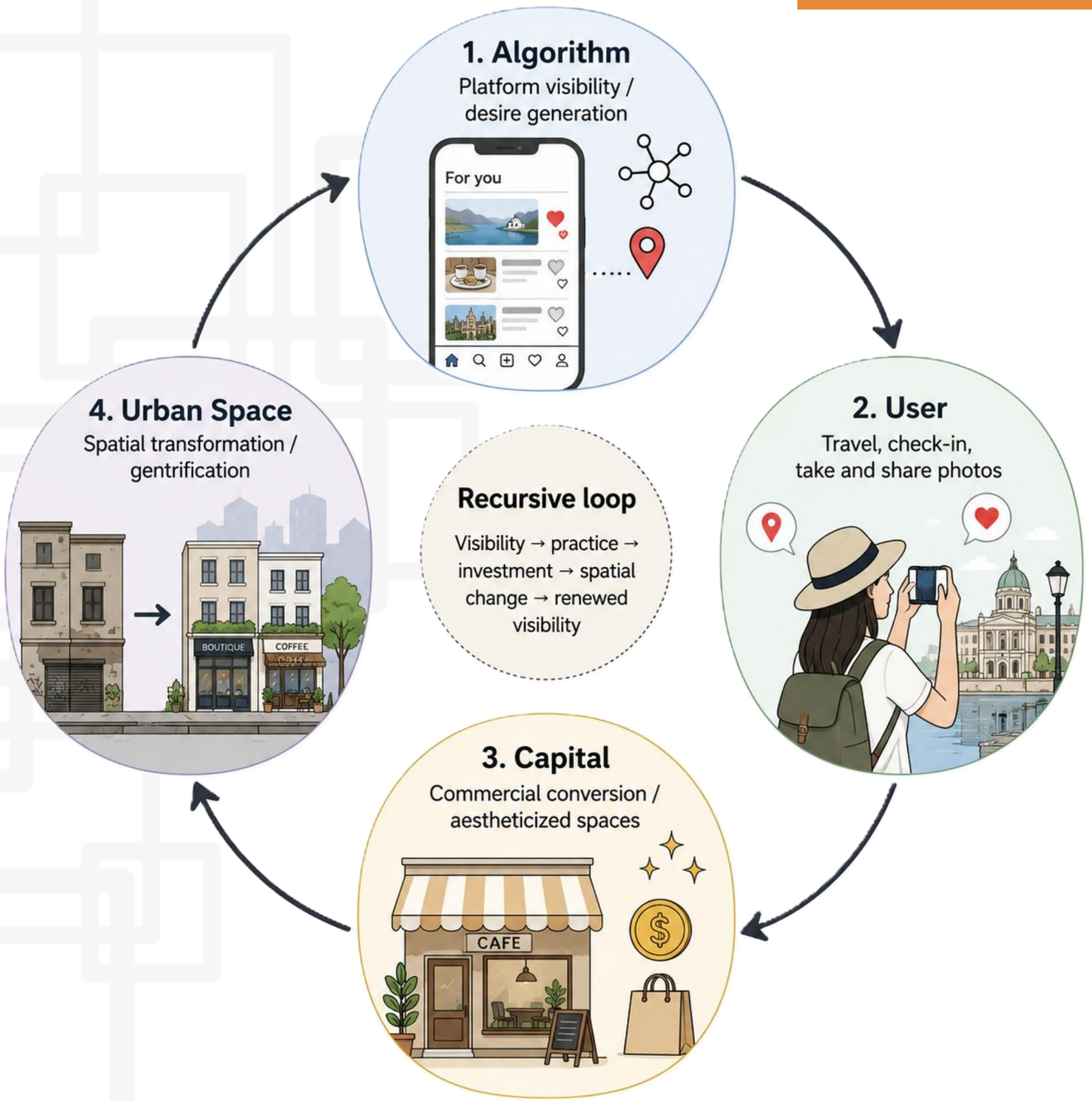
③ Museum of Ice Cream in Miami (USA)

④ Shop in Dongshankou, Guangzhou’s (China)





MOTIVATION & THEORETICAL BACKGROUND



Algorithm: Social media platforms plant consumption desire through algorithmic recommendations, geotagging, user metrics, and the amplification of visually shareable content.

User: Tourists perform "Daka" practices by visiting, checking in, imitating standardized poses and filters, and sharing photos/videos to accumulate digital capital and reinforce social recognition. They become **prosumers** because their consumption also produces content, visibility, and symbolic value.

Capital: Retailers, investors, influencers, and platform-oriented businesses convert digital visibility into economic value by designing aestheticized, "postable" atmospheres that encourage visitors to spend time, money, and attention.

Urban Space: These practices reshape the material city through the replacement of traditional shops, homogenized retail formats, photo-oriented spatial design, rent increases, merchant displacement, and gentrification.

Based on Ma & Wu (2026)

- Tourism is organized around the visual consumption of places. In the social media era, the **gaze** shifts from receptive to performative: tourists produce and circulate their own representations, closing a feedback loop between digital image and physical visit (Urry & Larsen, 2011; Larsen, 2024; Larsen et al., 2007)

- Sharing travel images is an exercise in conspicuous consumption (Veblen, 1899). The pursuit of likes and social validation operates in two directions: upward (distinction) and lateral (peer contagion through relative deprivation) (Soares et al., 2025; Jensen et al., 2025) in the "Tourism Circuit" (Ateljevic, 2000). There's a big industry with multiple value chains involved like in the "Wanghong economy" (Ma & Wu, 2026; Han, 2021)

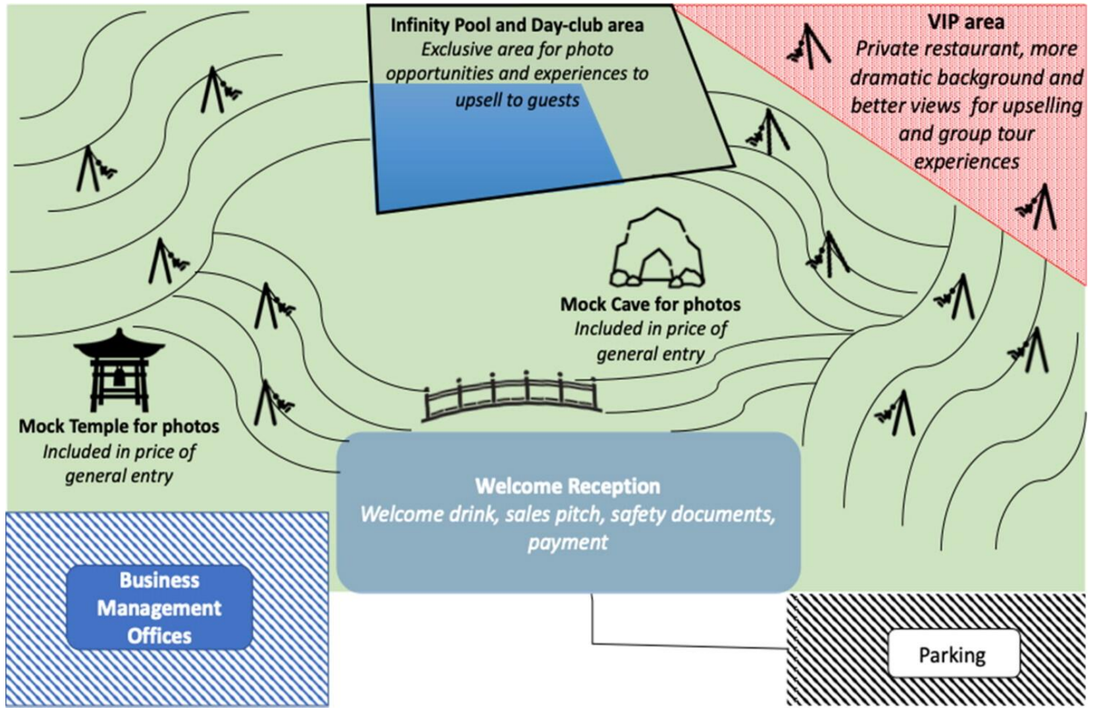
- Purpose-built *"selfie parks"* are enclavic spaces disconnected from local culture, operating through border-making and symbolic segregation. They are simulacra: images of images, with no original referent beyond shareability (Siegel et al., 2025; Saarinen, 2017).

"SELFIE-PARK"

A purpose-built, enclavic space designed to accommodate social media-induced tourists, positioned at the intersection of visual culture and spatial production.

Defining features

- No historical / cultural content required
- Architecturally designed photo frames & backdrops
- Ticketing, reservations, professional photo services
- Self-contained: replaces guides with brief texts/QR codes
- Lifecycle governed by social media virality
- Enclavic: limits linkages to host community
- Structurally exposed to rapid obsolescence



Mapped Selfie Park (Siegel et al. 2025)



How are purpose-built, visually oriented tourist attractions in the Global South (whose centrality resides in their photogenic and circulatory potential on social media platforms rather than in their historicity) **produced, legitimized and consumed** as simulacra of popular culture, monumentality and staged scenography?

In what ways do visitors and tourism suppliers co-create the symbolic and economic value of *instagrammable* attractions through practices of conspicuous consumption and distinction mediated by digital platforms?

Comparative case study (Gerring, 2004). At least two countries, different municipalities selected for their possession of purpose-built *instagrammable* attractions with demonstrated social media circulation.

Qualitative approach

- Etnography
- Netnography (Kessler et al., 2023)
- Content Analysis

Participant observation & Etnography

3 dimensions:

- Visitor behavior
- Management staging
- Spatial organization

Semi-estructured interview

30 interviews: 20 tourists + 10 stakeholders
Delphi validation of the instrument
Audio-recorded + transcription

Netnography

Public Instagram profiles (geotagged content)
Due to ethical concerns the study only analyses public content.
Focus: image circulation, hashtag networks, influencer roles

Content analysis

Combined inductive + deductive coding

Within-case → cross-case → theoretical synthesis

TOURISTS (n=20) + STAKEHOLDERS (n=10)

1 Motivation & Media-Induced Decision

Why this place? What role did social media content play in the decision to visit? Prior exposure to influencer content?

2 Photographic Practices

What is photographed, how, and with what intended audience in mind? Was the visit choreographed around planned shots?

3 Social Return & Digital Validation

Expected vs. actual reactions on platforms. Does this visit feel worth sharing compared to other experiences?

4 Authenticity & Cultural Meaning

Does the attraction reflect the local community's culture? Is it perceived as authentic, staged, or irrelevant to that question?

5 Identity, Distinction & Spatial Self

Does sharing this visit construct a particular identity? Relation to aspirational lifestyle and peer comparison.

LIMITATIONS & OPEN QUESTIONS (For discussion)

- Case selection still provisional. Requires systematic netnographic screening + local expert consultation.
- Independent fieldwork only in Spanish/English limits case selection options.
- Observer presence may influence behavior → mitigated by extended observation periods.
- Difficult to track initiatives; sometimes reported through local newspapers or media only. This phenomenon is not exclusive to the Global South, but in low- and middle-income countries tourism is suggested as an opportunity for growth and development — and private capital actively seeks opportunities to expand.



LIMITATIONS & OPEN QUESTIONS (For discussion)

- Meta® could provide access to aggregated platform data through its Graph API (subject to access restrictions). Unofficial APIs and web scraping tools could also be useful. Images could be analyzed too (shapes, tones, poses, text, etc.) **HOW?**

- Is netnography of public content ethically robust?
- Where is the boundary between a purpose-built selfie park and a conventional attraction that has simply been resignified as instagrammable?
- How to handle the representativeness of an interview sample recruited at the point of visit, which by design excludes those who visited but shared nothing?



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Thank You for your attention

Questions, comments, and critical pushback welcome.

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